

300

ESSENTIAL BUSINESS ENGLISH EXPRESSIONS

Meetings | Negotiations | Strategy | Leadership | Finance | and more

*A practical phrasebook for professionals who want to sound
natural, confident, and fluent at work.*

by [Your Name / Brand]

300 Essential Business English Expressions

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Welcome

Whether you're preparing for interviews, joining international calls, writing emails to clients, or simply want to sound more confident at work, this book gives you 300 real, commonly used expressions organized the way they actually come up in business life — by situation, not just alphabetically.

How each entry works:

Expression — the phrase itself, in natural business use.

Meaning — a clear, plain-English explanation.

Example — a realistic sentence from a real workplace context.

Register — how formal or casual the expression sounds.

Similar to — an alternative phrase you could use instead.

Tip: Don't try to memorize all 300 at once. Pick 5–10 a week from the chapters most relevant to your role, and start using them in real emails and meetings right away.

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01

MEETINGS & DISCUSSIONS

30 expressions in this chapter

01.01 Get the ball rolling

MEANING

To start something, such as a project or a discussion.

EXAMPLE

"Let's get the ball rolling on the Q3 budget review."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Kick things off

01.02 Touch base

MEANING

To make brief contact with someone to check on progress.

EXAMPLE

"I'll touch base with you after lunch to see how the report is coming along."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Check in

01.03 Circle back

MEANING

To return to a topic or person later.

EXAMPLE

"Let's circle back to the pricing question once marketing has shared their numbers."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Revisit

01.04 Put something on the table

MEANING

To formally propose an idea for discussion.

EXAMPLE

"I'd like to put a new remote-work policy on the table for next week's meeting."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Raise a point

01.05 Brainstorm

MEANING

To generate many ideas quickly, often as a group.

EXAMPLE

“Let's brainstorm a few names for the new product before we commit to one.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Bounce ideas around

01.06 Put something on hold

MEANING

To pause or delay a plan temporarily.

EXAMPLE

“We've put the office relocation on hold until the lease negotiations are finished.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Shelve it

01.07 Take the floor

MEANING

To begin speaking to a group, often formally.

EXAMPLE

“After the introduction, the CFO took the floor to present the annual results.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Have the floor

01.08 Weigh in

MEANING

To give one's opinion on a matter under discussion.

EXAMPLE

“Before we decide, I'd like everyone on the team to weigh in.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Chime in

01.09 Drill down

MEANING

To examine something in much greater detail.

EXAMPLE

“Can we drill down into the regional sales figures before the board meeting?”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Dig deeper

01.10 Chair a meeting

MEANING

To lead and direct the proceedings of a meeting.

EXAMPLE

“Priya will chair the meeting while the director is travelling.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Run a meeting

01.11 Loop someone in

MEANING

To include someone in a conversation or email so they stay informed.

EXAMPLE

“Could you loop in the legal team before we sign anything?”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Keep in the loop

01.12 Read between the lines

MEANING

To understand a hidden or implied meaning.

EXAMPLE

“He didn't say the project was cancelled, but if you read between the lines, that's clearly what happened.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Pick up on the subtext

01.13 Cut to the chase

MEANING

To get to the main point without wasting time.

EXAMPLE

“I know we're short on time, so let's cut to the chase — can we hit the deadline or not?”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Get to the point

01.14 Go off on a tangent

MEANING

To move away from the main subject of discussion.

EXAMPLE

"We went off on a tangent about office snacks and never finished the agenda."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Digress

01.15 Wrap up

MEANING

To bring a meeting or task to a close.

EXAMPLE

"Let's wrap up in the next five minutes so people can get to their next call."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Bring to a close

01.16 Take a rain check

MEANING

To postpone an invitation or plan to a later time.

EXAMPLE

"I'll have to take a rain check on lunch today — I've got back-to-back calls."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Reschedule

01.17 Run something by someone

MEANING

To share an idea with someone in order to get their opinion.

EXAMPLE

"Can I run a few slide ideas by you before I send the deck to the client?"

Register: Informal

Similar to: Get someone's take

01.18 Keep someone in the loop

MEANING

To continue sharing information with someone as things develop.

EXAMPLE

“Please keep me in the loop on the vendor negotiations.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Keep posted

01.19 Put a pin in it

MEANING

To pause discussion of a topic to return to it later.

EXAMPLE

“That’s a great question, but let’s put a pin in it and come back after the demo.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Table it

01.20 Hash it out

MEANING

To discuss something thoroughly until it is resolved.

EXAMPLE

“The two departments hashed it out in a two-hour meeting and finally agreed on the process.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Work it out

01.21 Sync up

MEANING

To meet briefly to align on shared information or plans.

EXAMPLE

“Let’s sync up tomorrow morning before the client call.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Get on the same page

01.22 Have the floor

MEANING

To have the right to speak while others listen.

EXAMPLE

“You have the floor — go ahead and present your findings.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Take the floor

01.23 Play devil's advocate

MEANING

To argue an opposing view deliberately, in order to test an idea.

EXAMPLE

“Let me play devil's advocate for a second — what if the client says no to this pricing?”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Poke holes in an idea

01.24 Steer the conversation

MEANING

To guide a discussion toward a particular topic or outcome.

EXAMPLE

“The facilitator steered the conversation back to budget once things drifted off track.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Redirect the discussion

01.25 Talk shop

MEANING

To discuss work-related matters, especially outside of formal settings.

EXAMPLE

“Even at the holiday party, the engineers ended up talking shop about the new release.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Talk business

01.26 Break the ice

MEANING

To ease tension or awkwardness at the start of an interaction.

EXAMPLE

“She told a quick joke to break the ice before the negotiation began.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Warm things up

01.27 Get down to business

MEANING

To stop making small talk and start the serious work.

EXAMPLE

“Once the coffee was poured, we got down to business and reviewed the contract terms.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Get to work

01.28 Air one's grievances

MEANING

To openly express complaints or concerns.

EXAMPLE

"The town-hall meeting gave staff a chance to air their grievances about the new policy."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Voice complaints

01.29 Give someone the floor

MEANING

To allow someone else to speak next.

EXAMPLE

"I'll give the floor to Marcus, who can walk us through the technical details."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Hand over the mic

01.30 Table a discussion

MEANING

To postpone a topic for a later meeting.

EXAMPLE

"Given the time, let's table this discussion and revisit it next week."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Defer the topic

02

NEGOTIATIONS & DEALS

30 expressions in this chapter

02.01 Meet halfway

MEANING

To compromise so that both sides give up something.

EXAMPLE

"Neither side got everything they wanted, but we met halfway on the delivery timeline."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Find a middle ground

02.02 Sweeten the deal

MEANING

To make an offer more attractive.

EXAMPLE

"To close the sale, we sweetened the deal with a free year of support."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Add incentives

02.03 Seal the deal

MEANING

To finalize an agreement.

EXAMPLE

"A firm handshake and a signed contract sealed the deal."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Close the deal

02.04 Drive a hard bargain

MEANING

To negotiate firmly and give little ground.

EXAMPLE

"Their procurement team drives a hard bargain — expect a tough round of talks."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Negotiate aggressively

02.05 Break the deadlock

MEANING

To find a way forward when negotiations have stalled.

EXAMPLE

"A last-minute compromise on price broke the deadlock."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Break the impasse

02.06 Give and take

MEANING

A process where both sides make concessions.

EXAMPLE

"Any good partnership involves a bit of give and take."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Mutual compromise

02.07 Play hardball

MEANING

To negotiate in an aggressive, uncompromising way.

EXAMPLE

"If they play hardball on the price, we'll need to consider other suppliers."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Negotiate tough

02.08 Reach a stalemate

MEANING

To arrive at a point where neither side will move further.

EXAMPLE

"Talks reached a stalemate after both sides refused to budge on the exclusivity clause."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Hit an impasse

02.09 Come to terms

MEANING

To reach an agreement after discussion.

EXAMPLE

"After weeks of back and forth, both parties came to terms on the licensing fee."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Reach an agreement

02.10 Call the shots

MEANING

To be the person who makes the decisions.

EXAMPLE

"In this deal, the investors are calling the shots."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Be in charge

02.11 Hold all the cards

MEANING

To be in a strong position with clear advantages in a negotiation.

EXAMPLE

"With three competing offers, the seller holds all the cards."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Have the upper hand

02.12 Leverage

MEANING

Power or advantage used to influence the outcome of a negotiation.

EXAMPLE

"Our exclusive technology gives us leverage in these talks."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Bargaining power

02.13 Bottom line

MEANING

The final, most important point, often the minimum acceptable outcome.

EXAMPLE

"Our bottom line is that we won't go below a 15% margin."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: The key point

02.14 Deal breaker

MEANING

A condition that, if not met, will end negotiations.

EXAMPLE

“Exclusivity is a deal breaker for us — we won't sign without it.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: A non-negotiable point

02.15 Win-win situation

MEANING

An outcome that benefits everyone involved.

EXAMPLE

“Splitting the shipping costs turned out to be a win-win situation for both companies.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Mutually beneficial outcome

02.16 Cut a deal

MEANING

To negotiate and agree on the terms of a transaction.

EXAMPLE

“We cut a deal with the landlord for a lower rent in exchange for a longer lease.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Strike a deal

02.17 Throw something in

MEANING

To add something extra to an offer at no additional cost.

EXAMPLE

“They threw in free installation to help us decide faster.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Include as a bonus

02.18 Haggle over price

MEANING

To argue back and forth about the cost of something.

EXAMPLE

“The two companies haggled over price for nearly a month before settling.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Bargain

02.19 On the table

MEANING

Available for discussion or consideration.

EXAMPLE

“A revised timeline is on the table if the client agrees to a smaller scope.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Up for discussion

02.20 Walk away from the table

MEANING

To end negotiations without reaching a deal.

EXAMPLE

“When they refused to lower the price, we walked away from the table.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Abandon talks

02.21 Up the ante

MEANING

To increase what is being risked or offered in order to gain advantage.

EXAMPLE

“Our competitor upped the ante with a lower bid, so we had to revise our offer.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Raise the stakes

02.22 Lock in a price

MEANING

To secure a fixed price for a set period.

EXAMPLE

“We locked in the shipping rate before the seasonal increase.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Secure a rate

02.23 Lowball offer

MEANING

An offer that is deliberately much lower than expected or fair.

EXAMPLE

"Their first bid was a lowball offer, so we countered immediately."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Undercut offer

02.24 Counteroffer

MEANING

An offer made in response to a rejected offer, adjusting the terms.

EXAMPLE

"We made a counteroffer that split the difference on delivery time."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Return offer

02.25 Close the gap

MEANING

To reduce the difference between two positions in a negotiation.

EXAMPLE

"A small discount helped close the gap between our offer and their expectations."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Narrow the difference

02.26 Play your cards right

MEANING

To act wisely in a situation to achieve the best outcome.

EXAMPLE

"If we play our cards right, we could land this account before the fiscal year ends."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Act strategically

02.27 Iron out the details

MEANING

To resolve the remaining small issues in an agreement.

EXAMPLE

"The lawyers spent an afternoon ironing out the details of the contract."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Finalize the specifics

02.28 Draw a line in the sand

MEANING

To set a firm limit that will not be crossed.

EXAMPLE

"We drew a line in the sand on the payment terms — 30 days, no exceptions."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Set a firm boundary

02.29 Give ground

MEANING

To make concessions in a negotiation.

EXAMPLE

"We had to give some ground on price to keep the client happy."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Make concessions

02.30 Clinch the deal

MEANING

To successfully secure an agreement, often at the final moment.

EXAMPLE

"A last-minute discount clinched the deal with the hesitant buyer."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Nail down the agreement

03

DEADLINES & TIME MANAGEMENT

30 expressions in this chapter

03.01 Down to the wire

MEANING

Continuing until the very last moment before a deadline.

EXAMPLE

"The negotiations went down to the wire, with the contract signed minutes before midnight."

Register: Informal

Similar to: At the last minute

03.02 Beat the clock

MEANING

To finish something before a deadline runs out.

EXAMPLE

"The team worked all weekend to beat the clock on the product launch."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Race the deadline

03.03 Time is of the essence

MEANING

A situation in which acting quickly is critical.

EXAMPLE

"Please respond today — time is of the essence with this offer."

Register: Formal

Similar to: There's no time to lose

03.04 Race against time

MEANING

To try to complete something before a limited time runs out.

EXAMPLE

"Engineers were racing against time to fix the bug before the demo."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Beat the clock

03.05 Buy some time

MEANING

To gain a short delay before something must happen.

EXAMPLE

"We asked the client for two extra days to buy some time for testing."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Gain a bit of breathing room

03.06 Against the clock

MEANING

Working under significant time pressure.

EXAMPLE

"The design team is working against the clock to finish before the trade show."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Under time pressure

03.07 Crunch time

MEANING

A critical period requiring intense effort before a deadline.

EXAMPLE

"It's crunch time for the finance team as the audit deadline approaches."

Register: Informal

Similar to: The final push

03.08 Burn the midnight oil

MEANING

To work late into the night on something.

EXAMPLE

"We've been burning the midnight oil all week to get the proposal ready."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Work late nights

03.09 Pressed for time

MEANING

Having very little time available to do something.

EXAMPLE

"I'm a bit pressed for time today, so let's keep the call short."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Short on time

03.10 Ahead of schedule

MEANING

Completed earlier than planned.

EXAMPLE

"The construction is running two weeks ahead of schedule."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Ahead of plan

03.11 Behind schedule

MEANING

Progressing more slowly than planned.

EXAMPLE

"The project fell behind schedule after the supplier delay."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Running late

03.12 On the back burner

MEANING

Set aside for now, to be dealt with later.

EXAMPLE

"We've put the rebranding project on the back burner until next quarter."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Deprioritized

03.13 Put something on ice

MEANING

To pause a plan indefinitely.

EXAMPLE

"The expansion plan was put on ice after the market downturn."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Freeze a plan

03.14 In the pipeline

MEANING

Currently being planned or developed, not yet complete.

EXAMPLE

"We have three new features in the pipeline for next quarter."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: In progress

03.15 Fast-track

MEANING

To speed up a process so it is completed sooner than usual.

EXAMPLE

"Management decided to fast-track the hiring process for the new role."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Accelerate

03.16 Eleventh-hour decision

MEANING

A decision made at the very last possible moment.

EXAMPLE

"It was an eleventh-hour decision, but the board approved the merger just before the deadline."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Last-minute call

03.17 Cut it close

MEANING

To complete something with very little time to spare.

EXAMPLE

"We cut it close on the filing deadline — just made it by an hour."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Barely make it

03.18 Moving target

MEANING

A goal or deadline that keeps changing.

EXAMPLE

“The launch date has been a moving target ever since the scope expanded.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Shifting goalpost

03.19 Push back a deadline

MEANING

To move a deadline to a later date.

EXAMPLE

“We had to push back the deadline by a week after the vendor delay.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Extend a deadline

03.20 Bring forward a meeting

MEANING

To move a meeting to an earlier time.

EXAMPLE

“Could we bring the meeting forward to Wednesday instead of Friday?”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Move up a meeting

03.21 Carve out time

MEANING

To deliberately make time for something in a busy schedule.

EXAMPLE

“Try to carve out time each week for strategic planning, not just firefighting.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Set aside time

03.22 Make time for

MEANING

To prioritize time for a specific activity or person.

EXAMPLE

“Even during the busy season, she makes time for one-on-one check-ins with her team.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Prioritize

03.23 Time crunch

MEANING

A period of severe time pressure.

EXAMPLE

"We're in a bit of a time crunch, so let's focus only on the essentials."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Crunch time

03.24 The long haul

MEANING

A lengthy period of time or effort required to complete something.

EXAMPLE

"Turning the company around will take the long haul, not a quick fix."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: A marathon, not a sprint

03.25 Short notice

MEANING

Very little advance warning before something happens.

EXAMPLE

"They asked us to present tomorrow, which is quite short notice."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Little advance warning

03.26 Day in, day out

MEANING

Happening every day without variation.

EXAMPLE

"The support team handles hundreds of tickets, day in, day out."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Every single day

03.27 Round the clock

MEANING

Continuously, 24 hours a day.

EXAMPLE

"Our customer service line operates round the clock."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Twenty-four seven

03.28 Run like clockwork

MEANING

To operate very smoothly and precisely, with good timing.

EXAMPLE

“Once the new system was in place, the warehouse ran like clockwork.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Operate seamlessly

03.29 Lose track of time

MEANING

To fail to notice how much time has passed.

EXAMPLE

“We lost track of time in the meeting and missed the next call.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Not notice the time

03.30 Time will tell

MEANING

The outcome of something will only become clear in the future.

EXAMPLE

“We’ve made our decision — only time will tell if it was the right one.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: We'll see how it plays out

04

PROBLEMS & CHALLENGES

30 expressions in this chapter

04.01 Hit a snag

MEANING

To encounter an unexpected small problem.

EXAMPLE

"We hit a snag with the vendor's system integration this morning."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Run into a hiccup

04.02 Iron out the wrinkles

MEANING

To resolve small remaining problems.

EXAMPLE

"We still need to iron out a few wrinkles before the software goes live."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Sort out the kinks

04.03 Back to square one

MEANING

To be forced to start something over again.

EXAMPLE

"After the client rejected the proposal, we were back to square one."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Start from scratch

04.04 A tough break

MEANING

An unfortunate event or piece of bad luck.

EXAMPLE

"It was a tough break for us when Caroline quit right before the launch."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Bad luck

04.05 Bite the bullet

MEANING

To accept something difficult or unpleasant that cannot be avoided.

EXAMPLE

"We had to bite the bullet and lay off part of the team to stay afloat."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Face the inevitable

04.06 Throw a wrench in the works

MEANING

To cause an unexpected problem that disrupts plans.

EXAMPLE

"The sudden regulation change threw a wrench in the works of our expansion plan."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Derail the plan

04.07 Up against the wall

MEANING

In a very difficult situation with few options remaining.

EXAMPLE

"With the deadline tomorrow and half the work left, we're up against the wall."

Register: Informal

Similar to: In a tight corner

04.08 Between a rock and a hard place

MEANING

Facing a difficult choice between two unfavorable options.

EXAMPLE

"We're between a rock and a hard place — cut costs or lose the client."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Stuck with no good option

04.09 Dodge a bullet

MEANING

To narrowly avoid a serious problem.

EXAMPLE

"We dodged a bullet by catching the contract error before it was signed."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Have a narrow escape

04.10 Put out fires

MEANING

To deal with urgent problems as they arise, rather than planned work.

EXAMPLE

"Half my day is spent putting out fires instead of working on strategy."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Firefight

04.11 The tip of the iceberg

MEANING

A small, visible part of a much bigger problem.

EXAMPLE

"These complaints are just the tip of the iceberg — there are deeper issues with the process."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Just the beginning of it

04.12 Get to the bottom of

MEANING

To discover the true cause of a problem.

EXAMPLE

"We need to get to the bottom of why shipments keep arriving late."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Find the root cause

04.13 A blessing in disguise

MEANING

Something that seems bad at first but turns out to have a positive result.

EXAMPLE

"Losing that client was a blessing in disguise — it freed us to focus on better accounts."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: A silver lining

04.14 Jump through hoops

MEANING

To go through many difficult or complicated steps to achieve something.

EXAMPLE

"We had to jump through hoops just to get the contract approved by compliance."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Go through a complicated process

04.15 An uphill battle

MEANING

A task that is very difficult to accomplish.

EXAMPLE

"Convincing the board to approve the new budget was an uphill battle."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: A tough fight

04.16 Hit a wall

MEANING

To reach a point where no further progress seems possible.

EXAMPLE

"We hit a wall in negotiations and had to bring in a mediator."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Reach an impasse

04.17 Patch things up

MEANING

To resolve a disagreement and restore good relations.

EXAMPLE

"After the miscommunication, the two teams patched things up over a joint lunch."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Smooth things over

04.18 Muddy the waters

MEANING

To make a situation more confusing or unclear.

EXAMPLE

“Adding more stakeholders to the decision only muddied the waters.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Complicate matters

04.19 A can of worms

MEANING

A situation that, once started, leads to many complicated problems.

EXAMPLE

“Renegotiating the contract opened up a whole can of worms with other clients.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: A complicated mess

04.20 Get the short end of the stick

MEANING

To receive an unfair or disadvantageous outcome.

EXAMPLE

“Smaller vendors often get the short end of the stick in these deals.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Get a bad deal

04.21 Weather the storm

MEANING

To survive a difficult period successfully.

EXAMPLE

“The company weathered the storm of the recession by cutting non-essential spending.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Ride out the difficulty

04.22 Cut corners

MEANING

To do something in an easier or cheaper way, often at the expense of quality.

EXAMPLE

“We won’t cut corners on quality control, even under a tight deadline.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Take shortcuts

04.23 Drop the ball

MEANING

To fail to do something one was responsible for.

EXAMPLE

"Someone dropped the ball on the client follow-up, and we lost the account."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Fail to follow through

04.24 Back to the drawing board

MEANING

To start planning again after a failed attempt.

EXAMPLE

"The prototype failed testing, so it's back to the drawing board for the design team."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Start over

04.25 Clean up the mess

MEANING

To fix problems caused by a previous mistake.

EXAMPLE

"The new manager spent his first month cleaning up the mess left by the old process."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Sort out the chaos

04.26 A thorn in one's side

MEANING

A persistent source of annoyance or trouble.

EXAMPLE

"That outdated legacy system has been a thorn in our side for years."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: A constant irritation

04.27 Skeletons in the closet

MEANING

Hidden problems or embarrassing facts from the past.

EXAMPLE

"The due diligence process uncovered a few skeletons in the closet at the target company."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Hidden past issues

04.28 Red flag

MEANING

A warning sign that something may be wrong.

EXAMPLE

“The sudden drop in engagement was a red flag for the product team.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Warning sign

04.29 Teething problems

MEANING

Early difficulties experienced when something new is being introduced.

EXAMPLE

“The new CRM had a few teething problems in the first month.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Early hiccups

04.30 A slippery slope

MEANING

A situation that, once begun, is likely to lead to a worse outcome.

EXAMPLE

“Allowing one exception to policy can be a slippery slope toward inconsistent enforcement.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: A dangerous precedent

05

SUCCESS & ACHIEVEMENT

30 expressions in this chapter

05.01 Ahead of the curve

MEANING

More advanced or innovative than others in the same field.

EXAMPLE

"We're investing in AI early so we can stay ahead of the curve."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Ahead of the pack

05.02 Ahead of the pack

MEANING

Better or more successful than the competition.

EXAMPLE

"If we want to stay ahead of the pack, we need to keep innovating."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Ahead of the curve

05.03 Hit the nail on the head

MEANING

To describe or identify something exactly right.

EXAMPLE

"Your analysis of the customer churn problem hit the nail on the head."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Get it exactly right

05.04 Raise the bar

MEANING

To set a higher standard than before.

EXAMPLE

"Their customer service raised the bar for the whole industry."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Set a new standard

05.05 Hit the ground running

MEANING

To start something immediately and effectively, without a slow start.

EXAMPLE

“The new hire hit the ground running and closed her first deal in week one.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Start strong

05.06 Go the extra mile

MEANING

To make an additional effort beyond what is expected.

EXAMPLE

“Our support team always goes the extra mile for customers.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Exceed expectations

05.07 Pull off a deal

MEANING

To successfully complete a difficult transaction.

EXAMPLE

“Against all odds, the team pulled off the deal before the quarter closed.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Land the deal

05.08 Exceed expectations

MEANING

To perform better than what was expected or required.

EXAMPLE

“The product launch exceeded expectations, doubling our forecasted sales.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Surpass targets

05.09 Reach new heights

MEANING

To achieve an unprecedented level of success.

EXAMPLE

“Under the new leadership, the company has reached new heights in revenue.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Achieve unprecedented success

05.10 Break new ground

MEANING

To do something innovative that has not been done before.

EXAMPLE

“Their research broke new ground in renewable energy storage.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Pioneer something

05.11 Make headway

MEANING

To make progress, especially after difficulty.

EXAMPLE

“We’re finally making headway on the compliance backlog.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Make progress

05.12 Gain traction

MEANING

To start becoming successful or popular.

EXAMPLE

“The new app has been gaining traction among younger users.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Build momentum

05.13 A game changer

MEANING

Something that significantly alters the way things are done.

EXAMPLE

“This new logistics software is a game changer for our delivery times.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: A breakthrough

05.14 Best in class

MEANING

The highest quality or standard within a category.

EXAMPLE

“Our onboarding experience is considered best in class in the industry.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Top of the class

05.15 Cutting edge

MEANING

The most advanced stage of development in a field.

EXAMPLE

“Our R&D; team works with cutting-edge machine learning techniques.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: State of the art

05.16 State of the art

MEANING

Using the most modern and advanced methods or technology.

EXAMPLE

“The new factory uses state-of-the-art automation.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Cutting edge

05.17 Hit a home run

MEANING

To achieve a great success.

EXAMPLE

“The marketing campaign hit a home run, tripling website traffic.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Score a big win

05.18 Knock it out of the park

MEANING

To perform exceptionally well.

EXAMPLE

“She knocked her presentation out of the park and won the client over.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Nail it

05.19 Turn the corner

MEANING

To start improving after a period of difficulty.

EXAMPLE

“After two rough quarters, the business has finally turned the corner.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Start improving

05.20 Bear fruit

MEANING

To produce good results after effort or time.

EXAMPLE

“Our investment in employee training is finally bearing fruit.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Pay off

05.21 Pay off

MEANING

To produce a beneficial result, usually after effort or risk.

EXAMPLE

“The long hours put into the pitch finally paid off with a signed contract.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Bear fruit

05.22 Come out on top

MEANING

To be the winner or most successful in a situation.

EXAMPLE

“Despite fierce competition, our bid came out on top.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Win out

05.23 A feather in one's cap

MEANING

An achievement to be proud of.

EXAMPLE

"Landing that global client was a real feather in her cap."

Register: Formal

Similar to: A notable achievement

05.24 Blaze a trail

MEANING

To be the first to do something, paving the way for others.

EXAMPLE

"The founder blazed a trail for sustainable manufacturing in the region."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Break new ground

05.25 Set the bar high

MEANING

To establish a demanding standard of performance.

EXAMPLE

"Last year's record sales set the bar high for this year's team."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Raise the bar

05.26 Rise to the occasion

MEANING

To perform well under pressure or in a challenging situation.

EXAMPLE

"When the client changed the scope last minute, the team rose to the occasion."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Step up

05.27 Hit the jackpot

MEANING

To achieve a very large or unexpected success.

EXAMPLE

"We hit the jackpot when that influencer mentioned our product for free."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Strike gold

05.28 Corner the market

MEANING

To gain such a large market share that competitors struggle to compete.

EXAMPLE

"The startup cornered the market for eco-friendly packaging within two years."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Dominate the market

05.29 Take the lead

MEANING

To be in first place or take charge of a situation.

EXAMPLE

"Our team took the lead on the merger integration project."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Get out in front

05.30 Make a name for yourself

MEANING

To become known or respected for something.

EXAMPLE

"She made a name for herself as the go-to expert on data privacy law."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Build a reputation

06

STRATEGY & PLANNING

30 expressions in this chapter

06.01 Think outside the box

MEANING

To think creatively, beyond conventional approaches.

EXAMPLE

"We need to think outside the box to solve this supply chain issue."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Think creatively

06.02 The big picture

MEANING

The overall situation, rather than the small details.

EXAMPLE

"Let's step back and look at the big picture before deciding on this feature."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: The overall view

06.03 Game plan

MEANING

A strategy or plan for achieving a goal.

EXAMPLE

"Our game plan for next quarter focuses on customer retention."

Register: Informal

Similar to: A strategy

06.04 Road map

MEANING

A plan that outlines the steps needed to achieve a longer-term goal.

EXAMPLE

"The product road map includes three major releases this year."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: A plan of action

06.05 The long game

MEANING

A strategy focused on long-term success rather than quick wins.

EXAMPLE

“We’re playing the long game with this market — profits will come in a few years.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: A long-term strategy

06.06 Play it by ear

MEANING

To decide how to act as a situation develops, without a fixed plan.

EXAMPLE

“We don’t have a detailed script for the client call — we’ll play it by ear.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Improvise

06.07 Lay the groundwork

MEANING

To do preparatory work before a bigger effort begins.

EXAMPLE

“This quarter is about laying the groundwork for next year’s expansion.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Set the foundation

06.08 Get the lay of the land

MEANING

To understand the basic situation or environment before acting.

EXAMPLE

“Before proposing changes, the new manager wanted to get the lay of the land.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Assess the situation

06.09 Hedge your bets

MEANING

To reduce risk by pursuing more than one option.

EXAMPLE

"We're hedging our bets by testing two different suppliers this quarter."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Spread the risk

06.10 Put all your eggs in one basket

MEANING

To risk everything on a single option or plan.

EXAMPLE

"Relying on a single client for most of our revenue puts all our eggs in one basket."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Bet everything on one thing

06.11 Keep your options open

MEANING

To avoid committing to a single choice too early.

EXAMPLE

"We're keeping our options open until we see both vendor proposals."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Stay flexible

06.12 Move the goalposts

MEANING

To unfairly change the criteria for success partway through.

EXAMPLE

"The client kept moving the goalposts, adding new requirements after each milestone."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Change the rules midway

06.13 Moving parts

MEANING

The various elements or factors involved in a complex situation.

EXAMPLE

"This merger has a lot of moving parts, from legal to HR to IT systems."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Many components

06.14 Connect the dots

MEANING

To see the relationship between different pieces of information.

EXAMPLE

“Once we connected the dots between the two data sets, the pattern became obvious.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: See the connections

06.15 Read the room

MEANING

To accurately sense the mood or attitude of people in a situation.

EXAMPLE

“A good negotiator knows how to read the room and adjust their approach.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Gauge the atmosphere

06.16 Take stock

MEANING

To review a situation carefully before deciding what to do next.

EXAMPLE

“After the product launch, the team took stock of what worked and what didn't.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Assess the situation

06.17 Map out a strategy

MEANING

To plan the details of an approach in advance.

EXAMPLE

“We spent the offsite mapping out our strategy for the next three years.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Plan out an approach

06.18 Build a case

MEANING

To gather evidence and arguments to support a proposal or decision.

EXAMPLE

“She built a strong case for investing in automation, backed by cost data.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Make an argument

06.19 Pivot

MEANING

To change strategy or direction significantly, often in response to new information.

EXAMPLE

“After the pilot failed, the startup pivoted to a subscription model.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Change direction

06.20 Fine-tune

MEANING

To make small adjustments to improve something.

EXAMPLE

“We just need to fine-tune the pricing model before we launch.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Make small adjustments

06.21 Streamline

MEANING

To make a process simpler and more efficient.

EXAMPLE

“We streamlined the approval process, cutting it from five steps to two.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Simplify a process

06.22 Scale up

MEANING

To increase the size or capacity of an operation.

EXAMPLE

“Once we validate demand, we plan to scale up production quickly.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Grow an operation

06.23 Low-hanging fruit

MEANING

Tasks or opportunities that are easy to achieve with minimal effort.

EXAMPLE

"Let's tackle the low-hanging fruit first, like fixing the checkout page."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Easy wins

06.24 A quick win

MEANING

A small success achieved with little effort, often early in a project.

EXAMPLE

"Automating the invoice reminders was a quick win for the finance team."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Low-hanging fruit

06.25 North star

MEANING

A guiding goal or principle that directs long-term decisions.

EXAMPLE

"Customer trust is our north star when evaluating any new feature."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Guiding principle

06.26 Proof of concept

MEANING

A small-scale demonstration to show that an idea is feasible.

EXAMPLE

"We built a proof of concept before asking for full funding."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Pilot test

06.27 Blue-sky thinking

MEANING

Creative thinking not limited by current constraints.

EXAMPLE

"The workshop encouraged blue-sky thinking about where the brand could go in ten years."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Unconstrained brainstorming

06.28 Join the dots

MEANING

To recognize patterns across separate pieces of information.

EXAMPLE

“Once analysts joined the dots across three reports, the trend was clear.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Connect the dots

06.29 Take a step back

MEANING

To pause and look at a situation from a broader perspective.

EXAMPLE

“Let's take a step back and reconsider whether this feature really matters to users.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Gain some perspective

06.30 Stay ahead of the game

MEANING

To anticipate changes and prepare before they happen.

EXAMPLE

“Investing in R&D; now helps us stay ahead of the game as the market shifts.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Stay one step ahead

07

TEAMWORK & COLLABORATION

30 expressions in this chapter

07.01 On the same page

MEANING

In agreement, sharing the same understanding.

EXAMPLE

"Before the call, let's make sure we're all on the same page about pricing."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Aligned

07.02 All hands on deck

MEANING

A situation requiring everyone's help and effort.

EXAMPLE

"It's all hands on deck this week as we prepare for the audit."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Everyone needed

07.03 Pull your weight

MEANING

To do one's fair share of the work.

EXAMPLE

"Every member of the team needs to pull their weight during crunch time."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Do your fair share

07.04 A team player

MEANING

Someone who works well with others and prioritizes group success.

EXAMPLE

"She's a great team player who always helps colleagues under pressure."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Collaborative colleague

07.05 Pitch in

MEANING

To contribute effort or help toward a shared task.

EXAMPLE

“Everyone pitched in to get the report finished before the holidays.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Chip in

07.06 Join forces

MEANING

To combine efforts with another person or group.

EXAMPLE

“The two departments joined forces to launch the new initiative.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Team up

07.07 Two heads are better than one

MEANING

Working together produces better results than working alone.

EXAMPLE

“Let’s review this together — two heads are better than one on something this important.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Collaboration beats solo work

07.08 Carry the team

MEANING

To take on an unusually large share of the work to support the group.

EXAMPLE

“During the outage, the on-call engineer carried the team through the crisis.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Shoulder the load

07.09 Pull together

MEANING

To unite and cooperate, especially in a difficult situation.

EXAMPLE

“The whole department pulled together to meet the year-end target.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Come together

07.10 Divide and conquer

MEANING

To split a large task into smaller parts handled by different people.

EXAMPLE

“Let's divide and conquer — you take the budget, I'll take the timeline.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Split the work

07.11 Many hands make light work

MEANING

A task becomes easier when many people contribute.

EXAMPLE

“With the whole team helping to move offices, many hands made light work of it.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Shared effort lightens the load

07.12 Go to bat for someone

MEANING

To support or defend someone, especially in a difficult situation.

EXAMPLE

“Our manager went to bat for us when the client complained unfairly.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Stand up for someone

07.13 Have someone's back

MEANING

To support and protect someone.

EXAMPLE

“Whatever happens in the meeting, I've got your back.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Support someone

07.14 Rally the troops

MEANING

To gather and motivate a team before a challenging task.

EXAMPLE

“Before the big pitch, the manager rallied the troops with a quick pep talk.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Motivate the team

07.15 Build bridges

MEANING

To establish good relationships between people or groups.

EXAMPLE

“The new director spent her first month building bridges between sales and engineering.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Foster relationships

07.16 Break down silos

MEANING

To improve communication and cooperation between separate departments.

EXAMPLE

“The company restructured to break down silos between marketing and product.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Improve cross-team collaboration

07.17 In the same boat

MEANING

Sharing the same difficult situation as someone else.

EXAMPLE

“Every retailer is in the same boat with rising shipping costs.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Facing the same situation

07.18 Shoulder to shoulder

MEANING

Working closely together in a united way.

EXAMPLE

“The two teams worked shoulder to shoulder to hit the launch date.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Side by side

07.19 Band together

MEANING

To unite as a group to achieve a common goal.

EXAMPLE

“The regional offices banded together to negotiate a better supplier rate.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Unite

07.20 Lend a hand

MEANING

To help someone with a task.

EXAMPLE

“Could you lend a hand with the client presentation this afternoon?”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Give a hand

07.21 Cover for someone

MEANING

To take on someone else's responsibilities temporarily.

EXAMPLE

“I’ll cover for you while you’re on leave next week.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Fill in for someone

07.22 Hold your own

MEANING

To perform competently, especially in a challenging situation.

EXAMPLE

“Even in her first big meeting, she held her own against seasoned negotiators.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Perform capably

07.23 Work hand in hand

MEANING

To collaborate very closely with someone.

EXAMPLE

"Our design and engineering teams work hand in hand on every release."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Collaborate closely

07.24 Bring something to the table

MEANING

To contribute a valuable skill, resource, or perspective.

EXAMPLE

"Each partner brings something different to the table in this joint venture."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Contribute value

07.25 Chip in

MEANING

To contribute money, effort, or ideas to a shared goal.

EXAMPLE

"Everyone chipped in to organize the client appreciation event."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Pitch in

07.26 Close ranks

MEANING

To unite firmly, especially in the face of criticism or a challenge.

EXAMPLE

"The leadership team closed ranks in support of the new strategy."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Present a united front

07.27 Get everyone on board

MEANING

To gain agreement and support from all involved.

EXAMPLE

"Before rolling out the new policy, we needed to get everyone on board."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Gain buy-in

07.28 Move as one

MEANING

To act in complete coordination as a group.

EXAMPLE

“Under tight deadlines, the crisis team moved as one.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Act in unison

07.29 Bring someone up to speed

MEANING

To give someone the latest information they need.

EXAMPLE

“Can you bring the new hire up to speed on the client account?”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Update someone

07.30 Pull in the same direction

MEANING

To work toward a common goal in an aligned way.

EXAMPLE

“Once the vision was clear, the whole company started pulling in the same direction.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Align toward a common goal

08

FINANCE & BUDGETS

30 expressions in this chapter

08.01 In the black

MEANING

Financially profitable; not in debt.

EXAMPLE

"After a tough first year, the business is finally in the black."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Profitable

08.02 In the red

MEANING

Losing money; in debt.

EXAMPLE

"The division has been in the red for three consecutive quarters."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Operating at a loss

08.03 Tighten the belt

MEANING

To reduce spending, especially during difficult financial times.

EXAMPLE

"We've had to tighten our belts after losing our biggest client."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Cut back on spending

08.04 Break even

MEANING

To reach a point where costs equal revenue, with no profit or loss.

EXAMPLE

"We expect to break even by the end of the second year."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Cover costs exactly

08.05 Cut costs

MEANING

To reduce expenses.

EXAMPLE

“Management asked every department to cut costs by 10% this year.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Reduce expenses

08.06 A cash cow

MEANING

A product or business that generates a steady, reliable profit.

EXAMPLE

“The subscription service has become a real cash cow for the company.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: A steady moneymaker

08.07 Burn rate

MEANING

The rate at which a company spends its available cash.

EXAMPLE

“At our current burn rate, we have about eight months of runway left.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Cash burn

08.08 Bang for your buck

MEANING

Good value in return for the money spent.

EXAMPLE

“This marketing channel gives us the most bang for our buck.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Good value for money

08.09 Penny-pinching

MEANING

Extremely careful, sometimes excessively so, about spending money.

EXAMPLE

“Some staff felt the new expense policy was overly penny-pinching.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Overly frugal

08.10 Nickel and dime

MEANING

To charge or worry about very small amounts of money repeatedly.

EXAMPLE

“Customers get frustrated when they feel nickel and dimed for every extra feature.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Charge for small extras

08.11 Foot the bill

MEANING

To pay for something, often on behalf of others.

EXAMPLE

“The company footed the bill for the entire team's travel expenses.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Pick up the tab

08.12 Cut your losses

MEANING

To stop investing in something that is failing, to avoid further loss.

EXAMPLE

“After two failed pilots, we decided to cut our losses and end the project.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Stop before losing more

08.13 A shoestring budget

MEANING

A very small amount of money to work with.

EXAMPLE

“The team launched the campaign on a shoestring budget and still exceeded targets.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: A minimal budget

08.14 Deep pockets

MEANING

Having a lot of money available to spend.

EXAMPLE

"Our competitor has deep pockets and can outspend us on advertising."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Substantial financial resources

08.15 Money is tight

MEANING

There is very little available money.

EXAMPLE

"Money is tight this quarter, so we're delaying non-essential purchases."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Funds are limited

08.16 Balance the books

MEANING

To ensure that income and expenses match correctly in financial records.

EXAMPLE

"The accounting team spends the last week of every month balancing the books."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Reconcile the accounts

08.17 Run the numbers

MEANING

To calculate or review financial figures carefully.

EXAMPLE

"Before we commit, let's run the numbers on both options."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Crunch the numbers

08.18 Crunch the numbers

MEANING

To analyze financial or statistical data carefully.

EXAMPLE

“Finance is crunching the numbers on the proposed acquisition.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Run the numbers

08.19 A slush fund

MEANING

Money set aside for flexible or informal, sometimes undisclosed, use.

EXAMPLE

“Every department has a small slush fund for unexpected client expenses.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: A discretionary fund

08.20 A rainy day fund

MEANING

Money saved for use in a future emergency.

EXAMPLE

“The company keeps a rainy day fund equal to six months of expenses.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Emergency savings

08.21 Sink or swim

MEANING

A situation where success depends entirely on one's own efforts, with no support.

EXAMPLE

“When the budget was cut, the new team was left to sink or swim on their own.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Succeed or fail alone

08.22 Return on investment

MEANING

The financial benefit gained relative to the amount invested.

EXAMPLE

“We need to show a clear return on investment before requesting more funding.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: ROI

08.23 Top line

MEANING

A company's total revenue, before expenses are deducted.

EXAMPLE

"Our top line grew 20% this year, even though profits stayed flat."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Gross revenue

08.24 Cost-cutting measures

MEANING

Actions taken specifically to reduce expenses.

EXAMPLE

"The company introduced several cost-cutting measures, including a hiring freeze."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Expense reduction steps

08.25 A sunk cost

MEANING

Money already spent that cannot be recovered, regardless of future decisions.

EXAMPLE

"We shouldn't keep funding this project just because of the sunk cost."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Money already spent

08.26 Break the bank

MEANING

To cost an excessive amount of money.

EXAMPLE

"A modest office renovation shouldn't break the bank."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Cost a fortune

08.27 Spare no expense

MEANING

To spend as much as necessary without limiting the budget.

EXAMPLE

"For the product launch event, the marketing team spared no expense."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Spend without limits

08.28 Live within your means

MEANING

To spend no more than one's available income.

EXAMPLE

"Even during the growth phase, the founders insisted on living within their means."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Spend responsibly

08.29 A financial cushion

MEANING

Extra money set aside to provide security against unexpected costs.

EXAMPLE

"Having a financial cushion helped the company survive the slow season."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: A safety net

08.30 Cook the books

MEANING

To manipulate financial records dishonestly.

EXAMPLE

"The scandal broke after auditors discovered the firm had been cooking the books."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Falsify accounts

09

LEADERSHIP & DECISION-MAKING

30 expressions in this chapter

09.01 Take the reins

MEANING

To take control or leadership of a situation.

EXAMPLE

"She took the reins of the department after the sudden resignation of the director."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Take charge

09.02 Lead by example

MEANING

To influence others through one's own actions rather than words.

EXAMPLE

"The best managers lead by example, arriving early and staying late when it matters."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Set an example

09.03 Make the call

MEANING

To make the final decision on a matter.

EXAMPLE

"It's a tough choice, but ultimately the CEO has to make the call."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Make the final decision

09.04 Take ownership

MEANING

To accept full responsibility for a task or outcome.

EXAMPLE

"I want each project lead to take ownership of their team's deliverables."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Own the outcome

09.05 Step up to the plate

MEANING

To take responsibility and act, especially when needed most.

EXAMPLE

“When the lead engineer left, the junior developer stepped up to the plate.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Rise to the challenge

09.06 Set the tone

MEANING

To establish the general mood or approach for a situation.

EXAMPLE

“The way you open the meeting will set the tone for the whole discussion.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Establish the mood

09.07 Read the writing on the wall

MEANING

To recognize clear signs that something is about to happen, usually negative.

EXAMPLE

“When sales started dropping, management read the writing on the wall and restructured early.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: See the signs

09.08 Put your foot down

MEANING

To insist firmly on something, refusing to change one's position.

EXAMPLE

“The finance director put her foot down and rejected the unbudgeted request.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Take a firm stand

09.09 Draw the line

MEANING

To set a clear limit on what is acceptable.

EXAMPLE

"We have to draw the line somewhere on scope changes, or the project will never end."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Set a boundary

09.10 Take a stand

MEANING

To state a firm position on an issue, especially a controversial one.

EXAMPLE

"The company took a stand on sustainability, even when it raised costs."

Register: Formal

Similar to: State a firm position

09.11 Weigh the pros and cons

MEANING

To carefully consider the advantages and disadvantages of a decision.

EXAMPLE

"Before signing, let's weigh the pros and cons of each vendor."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Consider the trade-offs

09.12 A gut feeling

MEANING

An instinctive sense about something, without clear evidence.

EXAMPLE

"I have a gut feeling this partnership will work out well."

Register: Informal

Similar to: An instinct

09.13 Sit on the fence

MEANING

To avoid committing to a decision or opinion.

EXAMPLE

"The board can't sit on the fence any longer — a decision is needed today."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Stay undecided

09.14 Err on the side of caution

MEANING

To choose the safer option when uncertain.

EXAMPLE

“Given the risks, let's err on the side of caution and delay the launch by a week.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Play it safe

09.15 Go with your gut

MEANING

To make a decision based on instinct rather than analysis.

EXAMPLE

“Sometimes there's no time for data — you just have to go with your gut.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Trust your instincts

09.16 Think on your feet

MEANING

To respond quickly and effectively to unexpected situations.

EXAMPLE

“When the client asked a tough question, she thought on her feet and handled it well.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Improvise well

09.17 Call it a day

MEANING

To decide to stop working on something for the time being.

EXAMPLE

“We've made good progress — let's call it a day and pick this up tomorrow.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Wrap up for the day

09.18 Take the bull by the horns

MEANING

To confront a difficult situation directly and decisively.

EXAMPLE

“Rather than wait, the manager took the bull by the horns and addressed the conflict head-on.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Tackle a problem head-on

09.19 Leave no stone unturned

MEANING

To try every possible option in order to achieve something.

EXAMPLE

“The investigation team left no stone unturned when reviewing the security breach.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Explore every option

09.20 Cross that bridge when you come to it

MEANING

To deal with a problem only when it actually arises, not in advance.

EXAMPLE

“We might face that regulatory issue later, but let's cross that bridge when we come to it.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Deal with it later

09.21 Play it safe

MEANING

To avoid risks by choosing a cautious course of action.

EXAMPLE

“Given the uncertain market, we decided to play it safe and delay the investment.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Err on the side of caution

09.22 Take a calculated risk

MEANING

To accept a risk after careful analysis of the potential outcome.

EXAMPLE

“Entering the new market was a calculated risk, based on solid research.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Take an informed risk

09.23 Put your money where your mouth is

MEANING

To back up one's words with real action or investment.

EXAMPLE

"If leadership believes in the strategy, they should put their money where their mouth is."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Back words with action

09.24 Lead the charge

MEANING

To be the one initiating and driving an effort forward.

EXAMPLE

"Our CTO is leading the charge on the digital transformation project."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Spearhead an effort

09.25 Hold the fort

MEANING

To manage responsibilities temporarily while someone else is away.

EXAMPLE

"Can you hold the fort while I'm at the conference next week?"

Register: Informal

Similar to: Keep things running

09.26 Delegate authority

MEANING

To assign decision-making power to someone else.

EXAMPLE

"Good leaders know when to delegate authority rather than control every detail."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Assign decision-making power

09.27 Empower the team

MEANING

To give team members the confidence and authority to act independently.

EXAMPLE

"Empowering the team to make small decisions sped up our whole workflow."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Give the team autonomy

09.28 Set the wheels in motion

MEANING

To start a process that will lead to a particular result.

EXAMPLE

“Signing the lease sets the wheels in motion for our office expansion.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Get things started

09.29 Steer the ship

MEANING

To guide and manage an organization or project.

EXAMPLE

“With the founder on leave, the COO is steering the ship for now.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Be in charge

09.30 Make an executive decision

MEANING

To make a final decision quickly, often without consulting everyone.

EXAMPLE

“With no time to debate further, she made an executive decision and moved forward.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Make a unilateral call

10 COMMUNICATION & FEEDBACK

30 expressions in this chapter

10.01 Get the message across

MEANING

To successfully communicate an idea so it is understood.

EXAMPLE

"The new poster campaign finally got the safety message across to staff."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Communicate effectively

10.02 Beat around the bush

MEANING

To avoid saying something directly, often because it is uncomfortable.

EXAMPLE

"Stop beating around the bush and tell me if the deal fell through."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Avoid the point

10.03 Give it to someone straight

MEANING

To tell someone the truth directly, without softening it.

EXAMPLE

"I appreciate that you gave it to me straight about the report's weaknesses."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Be blunt

10.04 Sugarcoat

MEANING

To make something unpleasant sound better than it really is.

EXAMPLE

"Don't sugarcoat it — just tell me if we missed the target."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Soften bad news

10.05 Constructive criticism

MEANING

Feedback intended to help someone improve, given in a helpful way.

EXAMPLE

"Her manager offered constructive criticism on how to improve the presentation."

Register: Formal

Similar to: Helpful feedback

10.06 Food for thought

MEANING

Information or ideas that are worth thinking about seriously.

EXAMPLE

"Your suggestion about outsourcing is definitely food for thought."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Something to consider

10.07 On the same wavelength

MEANING

Thinking in a similar way to someone else, understanding each other easily.

EXAMPLE

"After a few projects together, we're really on the same wavelength now."

Register: Informal

Similar to: In sync

10.08 Lost in translation

MEANING

Meaning that is misunderstood or lost between people, often across languages or contexts.

EXAMPLE

"Some of the nuance in the client's feedback got lost in translation during the handoff."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Misunderstood in the process

10.09 Get your point across

MEANING

To make sure others understand what you mean.

EXAMPLE

“Use simple examples to get your point across to a non-technical audience.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Make yourself understood

10.10 Straight from the horse's mouth

MEANING

Information heard directly from the original, reliable source.

EXAMPLE

“I heard about the merger straight from the horse's mouth — the CEO told me himself.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: From a reliable primary source

10.11 Hear it through the grapevine

MEANING

To learn information through informal gossip or rumor.

EXAMPLE

“I heard through the grapevine that there might be layoffs next month.”

Register: Informal

Similar to: Hear it as a rumor

10.12 Keep someone posted

MEANING

To continue giving someone updates.

EXAMPLE

“I’ll keep you posted as soon as I hear back from the client.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Keep someone updated

10.13 Put it in writing

MEANING

To confirm something formally in a written document.

EXAMPLE

“Please put the agreed terms in writing before we proceed.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Document it formally

10.14 Spell it out

MEANING

To explain something clearly and in detail, leaving no ambiguity.

EXAMPLE

"Let's spell out exactly what's included in the service package."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Explain in detail

10.15 Drop someone a line

MEANING

To send a short, informal message to someone.

EXAMPLE

"Drop me a line once the contract has been signed."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Send a quick message

10.16 Touch on a point

MEANING

To mention a topic briefly, without going into full detail.

EXAMPLE

"The CEO touched on the restructuring plans but saved details for next week."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Mention briefly

10.17 Make a long story short

MEANING

To summarize something briefly rather than giving all the details.

EXAMPLE

"To make a long story short, the deal fell through over pricing."

Register: Informal

Similar to: To sum up

10.18 Get to the point

MEANING

To state the main idea directly, without unnecessary detail.

EXAMPLE

“We only have five minutes, so let's get to the point.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Cut to the chase

10.19 Speak volumes

MEANING

To convey a great deal of meaning without words, or through a small action.

EXAMPLE

“The client's silence after the pitch spoke volumes about their hesitation.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Convey a lot without saying much

10.20 Mixed signals

MEANING

Confusing or contradictory messages that make intentions unclear.

EXAMPLE

“The client is sending mixed signals — one email says yes, the next says they need more time.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Contradictory messages

10.21 Open the floor for questions

MEANING

To invite an audience to ask questions.

EXAMPLE

“After the presentation, she opened the floor for questions.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Invite questions

10.22 Take feedback on board

MEANING

To seriously consider and act on suggestions or criticism.

EXAMPLE

“The design team took the client's feedback on board and revised the layout.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Act on feedback

10.23 Give someone the benefit of the doubt

MEANING

To assume the best about someone despite uncertainty.

EXAMPLE

"Let's give him the benefit of the doubt — he may not have received the email."

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Assume good intent

10.24 Sound out an idea

MEANING

To informally test how others feel about an idea before proposing it fully.

EXAMPLE

"I want to sound out the idea with a few colleagues before bringing it to the board."

Register: Informal

Similar to: Test the waters

10.25 Pick someone's brain

MEANING

To ask someone for their knowledge or opinion on a subject.

EXAMPLE

"Could I pick your brain about the vendor selection process?"

Register: Informal

Similar to: Ask for advice

10.26 Throw out an idea

MEANING

To suggest an idea casually, often for others to consider.

EXAMPLE

"Just to throw out an idea, what if we bundled the two services together?"

Register: Informal

Similar to: Suggest something casually

10.27 Voice a concern

MEANING

To express worry or objection about something.

EXAMPLE

“Two team members voiced concerns about the tight rollout schedule.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Raise a concern

10.28 Air out differences

MEANING

To openly discuss disagreements in order to resolve them.

EXAMPLE

“The two co-founders aired out their differences before the investor meeting.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Discuss disagreements openly

10.29 Strike the right tone

MEANING

To communicate in a manner appropriate to the situation.

EXAMPLE

“The apology email struck the right tone — sincere but not overly dramatic.”

Register: Formal

Similar to: Communicate appropriately

10.30 Tone down a message

MEANING

To make a message less strong or forceful.

EXAMPLE

“Let's tone down the message a bit — we don't want to sound aggressive to the client.”

Register: Neutral

Similar to: Soften a message

Thank You!

I hope these 300 expressions help you communicate with more confidence at work.

If this book was useful, a quick review on the platform where you bought it really helps — and it helps other learners find it too.

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